Soft Apocalypse 2026

The Derozio Prize: Poetry

Named after the Indian Poet, Henry Vivian Derozio

Technical Mastery: The winning poem shall demonstrate a conscious, earned relationship with form, whether that form is inherited or invented. Line breaks that do work. Syntax that creates pressure. Silence that means something. The judges will not reward technical display for its own sake, but they will notice its absence immediately.

Lyrical Innovation: Poetry that sounds like the decade it was written in, not the century before it. This does not mean experimental for its own sake; it means a poet who has absorbed the tradition and chosen, deliberately, where to push against it. An image that has not been used before. A structural decision that surprises and then, on reflection, feels inevitable.

Emotional Depth and Necessity: The question the judges will ask of every poem submitted is: did this need to be written? A technically accomplished poem that has nothing urgent inside it will not win this prize. The Derozio Prize goes to the poem that carries weight, that costs the poet something, and gives the reader something they did not know they were missing.

Voice and Distinctiveness: Derozio himself was unmistakable on the page at nineteen. The prize named for him will go to a poet who is already, at whatever age, entirely themselves.

Best Regards,
Soft Apocalypse Team.